project was so large and courtiers were so enthralled by the images that court chroniclers meticulously recorded the progress of the work. ‘Verily it is a book the like of which no connoisseur has seen since the azure sheets of the heavens were decorated with brilliant stars…’ wrote a courtier, quite overcome.

The paintings were extraordinary for their large scale, over a metre tall, and for the use of a cloth rather than paper ground. They were to be used as props during the recitations of the qissa-khwans, held up in front of the storyteller as the corresponding sections were narrated. Akbar was personally involved in the themes of the images and the minutiae of the painting process. He chose the scenes to be painted himself and enquired about the quality of the raw materials used, insisting on the very best. The outlines were painted by either one of the Persian masters, or another leading master, following which a junior artist coloured in the images. Every week the images were presented before Akbar and the Padshah gave out rewards and increased allowances according to the brilliance of the work. ‘As a result,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl, ‘colouring has gained a new beauty and finish a new clarity…delicacy of work, clarity of line and boldness of execution…have reached perfection, and inanimate objects appear to come alive.’

According to art historian John Guy, though the *Hamzanama* contains glimpses of various north Indian and Deccani styles, understandable because of the varied backgrounds of the artists employed, there is nonetheless a unifying theme of energy, vitality, and action, no doubt because of the overall creative vision of a single master artist. Here, for the first time, we see the two worlds of the Mughals, the Persianate–Timurid world and the Hindustani one, fused to form a unique, new creation. Persian delicacy and flat linear forms jostle with Hindustani vigour and exuberant colour. Angular, precise shapes are intruded upon unexpectedly by typically Hindustani animals, birds, and flowers. One of the Hindustani artists discovered during this period was young Daswant, son of a palki-bearer.* ‘Urged by natural desire,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl, ‘he used to draw images and designs on the walls.’ Akbar chanced upon this graffiti one day and was impressed with the young scribbler, who was commended to the master artist of the taswir khana. ‘In just a short time,’ added Abu’l Fazl, ‘he became matchless in his skills’, pointing both to Daswant’s genius and the outstanding social mobility possible at Akbar’s court. Once the *Hamzanama*